

COUNTER INFORMATION

JULY/AUG 1987

CLAIMANTS TAKE OVER TOWN HALLS



Claimants occupy Haringey Town Hall

Claimants occupied 3 London Town Halls to demand emergency payments from local Councils during the Civil Servants' strike from 5 - 8th May.

A London claimant reports:

Islington: After pressure from *Barnsbury Claimants Union* (including leafleting claimants calling on them to go to the Town Hall to demand money), the Council decided to pay Urgent Needs Payments (£27 per person) to all claimants. Local DHSS strikers (CPSA Union) pass resolution refusing to collect back, after they return to work, any monies paid out to claimants.

Camden: Over 100 claimants (swelling to 300), supported by a few strikers, occupy the Town Hall on May 5th, demanding money. Security thugs try to prevent entry by punching people, old and young. The angry occupiers hold the Council Chambers for 6 hours - until the Council agrees to pay all local claimants around £28.50 per person. But, treacherously, the Council make claimants sign forms saying the money could be taken off their future benefit.

Hackney: In 1983, during a long DHSS strike, 1,000 claimants occupied the Town Hall and forced the Council to pay out. This time, under pressure

Council agrees to distribute food from Town Hall. Local Union official declares it "strikebreaking" - and Town Hall is closed *completely*. 40 claimants, supported by 60 outside, use a ladder to occupy a committee room demanding money. After 2 days, Council allow police to smash their way in and evict the claimants. **Haringey:** *Tottenham Claimants Union* call for claimants to rally at Civic Centre on 8th May. Some strikers support (after discussing all week on picket lines etc. both the local branches of CPSA strikers and NALGO Union Town Hall workers agree that payments should be made by the Council). Whilst local politicians come out to make speeches, 120 penniless claimants go and occupy the Council chamber. Council say they'd agreed to pay out but that one NALGO Union official refuses to let 'his' members sign the cheques. After 4 hrs., Bernie Grant (leader of the Council) orders staff out of the Town Hall and calls in the police who violently evict the occupiers. 80 people then go and occupy the

nearby Finance Dept. and talk to workers. Police arrive in 15 minutes. After a meeting in nearby community centre, we march down the High Road chanting "We want money" and 30 occupy a Social Security office before going home.

The claimants groups fighting for emergency payments all support the Civil Servants' struggle for better wages and conditions.

The argument put by some Union leaders that such emergency payments are "strikebreaking" is stupid. Claimants can't support the

Civil Servants fight if they're starving. If the state is forced to pay out extra money to claimants that makes the strike more effective. To really benefit claimants, and to impose more costs on the government, these payments must NOT be taken off claimants' future giros.

More info: Camden Unemployment Action Centre, 105 St. Pancras Way, London, NW1. Tottenham Claimants Union, c/o 628 High Road, London, N17.

Lothian Claimants Union c/o E.U.W.C. 2, Cranston St, Edinburgh

EDINBURGH: With giros delayed by civil servants strike action, claimants occupied Lothian Regional Council HQ on both 18th & 19th June to demand emergency payments.

Two Claimants Involved Report

Leafleting & poster by Lothian Claimants Union resulted in a claimants mass meeting on the 18th. Claimants & a civil service striker spoke. The Tory government were to blame for claimant's hardship, not the strikers. And all that the Labour Council was providing for claimants in Edinburgh was soup kitchens. **ACTION WAS NEEDED.**

70-80 of us made for the Council HQ, went straight inside & occupied a large room. "Elect a small delegation" said the Council representatives. "We are all spokespersons" we replied. We discussed our aims & views among ourselves. After 1½ hours Council representatives promised each claimant would get a £5 food voucher per day for 4 days. And it seemed they'd agreed to pay us in one go. Claimants wouldn't have to repay the Council and NOTHING would be taken off our future giros.

We then left. A mistake. We

should have stayed in the council building until we actually got the vouchers - or, better, cash - in our hands. Because, though the Council subsequently made some vouchers available, they didn't pay the amount promised.

By noon the next day most claimants had only got £10 worth of vouchers, not £20. Angry at this, 30-35 claimants occupied the Council HQ again. Council reps claimed they'd only promised to pay £10's worth of vouchers altogether! liars! Eventually they used the police to evict us.

Later the Council paid out for a third day's vouchers.

To sum up - claimants direct action won a partial victory. And for future strikes? Claimants should force the Council to pay out cash if possible, food vouchers if not - from Council premises (this time there was too much pressure on the Unemployed Workers Centre as a voucher distribution point). But if there's an all-out indefinite strike new tactics might be needed, claimants will have to act together to satisfy our material needs, direct action against central government property & mass shoplifting would be 2 real possibilities.

ANTI-CENSUS NEWS!

On the morning of 1st May police in West Berlin raided the Census Bureau Information Office. Thousands of leaflets calling for a boycott of the May 25th census were 'confiscated'.

The last attempt to carry out a census in 1983 was *defeated by broad resistance* of the population.

The results of this census are to be passed on to private industry and used by the police to compile so-called *criminality atlases* to recognise and stifle resistance in its very be-

ginning. The roots of the census go back to nazi times.

With the coming to power of the fascists in 1933 began the 'golden age' of German statistics. The nazis needed reliable data to be able to plan their war - and extermination

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NOBODY WINS

Response to the General Election result varies from anger to resignation. Anger prevails in the areas, especially Scotland and Wales, where a decisive rejection of Government policies has threatened the legitimacy of its 'mandate' to rule in a centralist fashion. Resignation prevails in areas, such as London and the midlands, where selfish concerns have been exploited by the Tories in contrast to the needs of the dispossessed.

Labour will seek to gag struggles so that their 'responsible' face is sold for electoral gain. Such will be the growing inequality and cuts to the Welfare State pursued by Tory policies that effective opposition will have to throw off the shackles of Labourism. Measures such as JTS, benefit cuts and the Poll Tax will generate opposition in the streets which even TV hacks like Robin Day can foresee. The needs of those in struggle will be exploited by the Labour Left and their hangers on; they must not be allowed to subordinate and regiment our struggles.

For the record, CI collective members did not vote. We didn't waste time urging people not to. As internationalists, our concern remains the spread of determined resistance wherever the power of the rulers intervenes in our lives. It is also manifest in the need to counter the lies and shallow concerns of the Mass Media and the need to develop direct reporting of struggles for widespread distribution.

The Green Party tried to win publicity for their Alternative policies challenging the link between employment and basic needs, and the freedom of Companies to despoil the environment and super-exploit the 3rd World.

By directing their energies to elections and lobbying they are destined to fail. We are no nearer socialism through such a parliamentary road. Any expression of support that Green Politics has had, in W. Germany, has arisen out of the history of opposition in communities to the nuclear state, not the other way round. If such a movement grew to threaten the functioning of the State, the time will have already passed for electioneering and a civil war underway in which the reform of capital is an irrelevance.

SOUTH AFRICA

AFTER 12 months of unrelenting repression, Apartheid's rulers have arrived at a false 'dawn'. Botha's Freedom of Sharpeville and surrounding towns is a message that the military presence is for the time being strong enough to protect the Black Councillors against the wrath of their own townships.

Centres of resistance such as Lange in the East Cape were razed to the ground and vigilante squads recruited to attack the Action Committees and terrorise those not amongst the 28,000 interned. Now as Treason charges are being brought against the *Alexandria 47* (including Metal Workers leader Moses Mayekiso), the State is increasingly trying to stem the continuing militancy amongst black workers.

With township and school student resistance driven underground or dispersed, it is at work, the point of exploitation, that the political challenge is developing. The Rail workers won a courageous strike against all the odds. 16,000 Black workers refused to be intimidated by military occupation by the Security forces, the hostility of white workers and the 'dirty tricks' campaign against their union federation, COSATU.

The workers have been reinstated without loss of benefits. They have gained ground by being granted a 'permanent status' previously only reserved for whites, and the right to openly join COSATU's affiliate. They also have the memory of a struggle during which 6 strikers were shot dead at Witwatersrand, and where they took direct action in petrol bomb attacks and effectively paralysed the rail service around Johannesburg.

This will prove an inspiration to workers from the townships fighting for basic rights. One such struggle under way in *Witbank, North Transvaal*, is against the men only hostels with families exiled in the homelands. By occupying dormitories the NUM members and their families are also challenging the temporary contract system. From small beginnings tribal divisions can be undercut and opposition generated against a system which 'reforms' within the

ACTION AGAINST RACISM

In *Gerzensee* (Switzerland), during February 1987, there was an unpublicised, international meeting of police and government representatives to co-ordinate measures against "undesirable immigrants".

In Britain the government introduced; a computerised check system at ports and airports containing 20,000 names, £1,000 fines for companies bringing in passengers without visas and the removal of an automatic right of appeal against deportation. Most sinister of all is the use of "prison ships" to detain suspected illegal immigrants.

There is however, organised resistance to racism.

VIRAJ MENDIS

Viraj, an anti-racist activist, has been living under the threat of deportation to *Sri Lanka*. His support for the Tamils makes this a death threat.

On December 20th he took sanctuary in a Manchester church. Following a smear campaign, orchestrated by the Home Office, the sanctuary was attacked several times. On February 9th a supporter was assaulted and had a

swastika carved on the back of her hand.

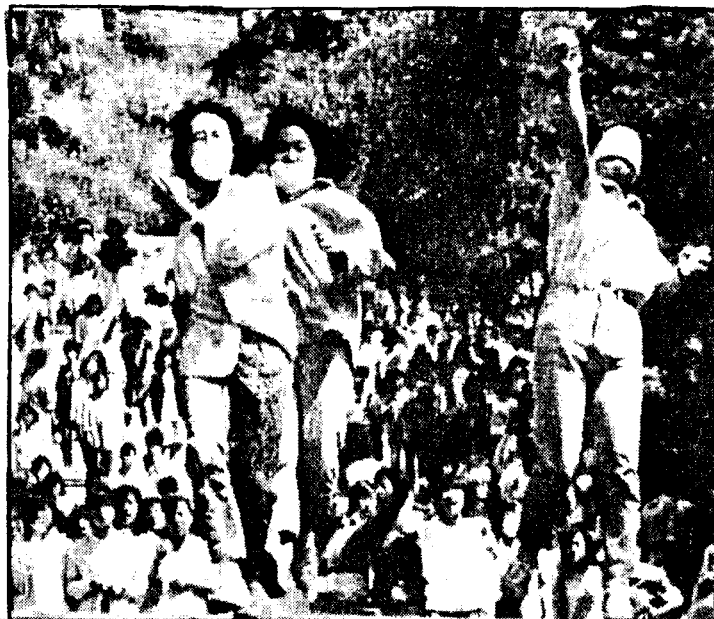
The Viraj Mendis Defence Campaign rather than being intimidated has pursued its aim of uniting separate anti-deportation and related struggles into a broad anti-racist movement.

TOWER HAMLETS

Those nice people, the Liberals who rule in *Tower Hamlets*, E. London, are trying to evict 80 Bangladeshi families, some of whom have lived there for twenty years, because they made themselves "intentionally homeless" by leaving Bangladesh.

On April 27th over 200 people invaded the council chamber to protest. The police arrived, some in riot gear, and forced the demonstrators out. Six people were arrested and the protest continued outside Bethnal Green police station. Several windows were smashed.

Hundreds of Bangladeshis marched on the Town Hall on May 5th and held a noisy rally - but the council had fled. The Homeless families campaign is continuing to picket the local Liberal Club.



In one of the most policed countries in the 'Western' world, protests in South Korea are upstaging preparations for next year's Olympic Games. 16 police stations were attacked, riot police were surround-

ed and had their tear gas masks removed and an international football match abandoned. Tens of thousands of activists turned the exclusive shopping district of Seoul, the capital, into a battleground.

interests of Institutionalised Racism.

During the run up to the election, COSATU offices were closed by arson and military force and released school student detainees are being replaced by union activists. It is up to us to increase aware-

ness here by campaigning against the Companies who profit from their South African subsidiaries, the import of their produce or the export of arms. By exposing the bankruptcy of 'liberal' Companies the solution is posed for Southern Africa, opposition to capitalism in all its forms.

SPAIN TOO RECENTLY SUFFERED AN ELECTION CAMPAIGN. BUT MORE POSITIVE ACTIVITY IS ALSO UNDERWAY, AS THE REVOLUTIONARY GROUP ETCETERA REPORT:

Elections need social peace. Those in power and those who would like power attempt to dissolve workers' autonomous action against the interests of the profit - economy into a system of political representation.

At election time the government's rhetoric & lies are more strident than ever and they make promises to try to contain and stall workers' demands.

At the moment the government's lies have not succeeded in weakening the struggles of various workers collectives against a worsening of their wages and working conditions and so, the same workers who during the electoral spectacle could vote for the government, confront it and its economic policy in the streets and in the factory. A healthy paradox which still makes social revolution possible.

The workers struggles which have been taking place in Spain over the last few months did not let up during the electoral period. The workers are not abandoning action in the street.

BARRICADES

In **REINOSA** the workers are still mobilising. The workforces at Forjas & Aceros continue to hold assemblies and take action. On 20th May they succeeded in barricading the railway line and the road. On 26th May they obstructed traffic on the main **SATANDER - PALENCIA** road.

PEOPLES POWER

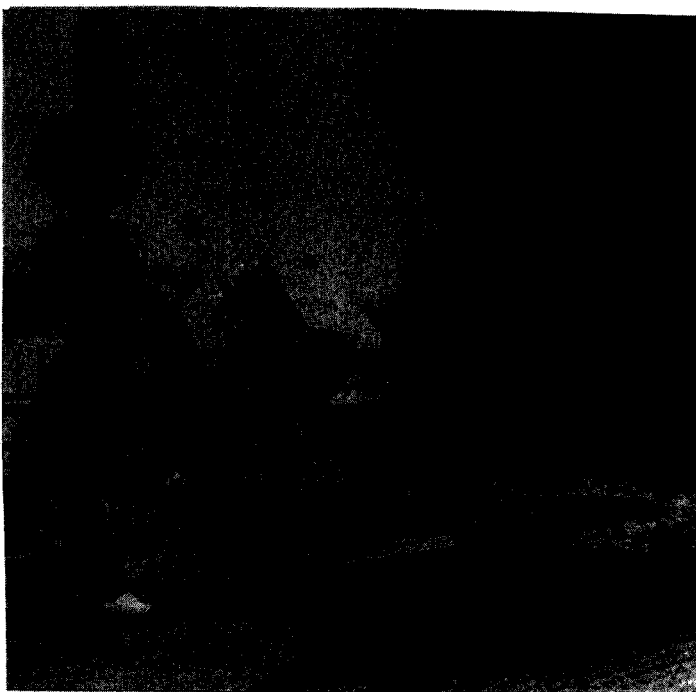
Since President *Aquino* came to power in the Philippines on the "peoples power" ticket, peoples power has never been so under threat!

On the 24th Jan. a rally was held by the workforce of a *free trade zone*, which employs mostly women as cheap labour, asking for the repeal of the old Marcos anti-strike laws & also demanding higher wages.

On the 27th, the barricades were erected outside the zone & strike action begun.

Negotiations were begun with the authorities who admitted the "reasonableness of the demands".

BATTLING ON



The workers of **EUSKALDUNA** have already taken part in one of the fiercest struggles against the present government's plans for industrial re-structuring. On 20th May they barricaded the **DEUSTO** bridge and blocked off access to Bilbao.

BLOW

In **PUERTO REAL** the government's economic policies have struck a harsh blow to 3,500 workers from the Spanish Steelworks S.A. - this represents 80% of the economic activity in the city. Here the workers continue to mobilize autonomously.

After the new closure plans announced on the 19th May the barricades were erected again,

till the 28th. On that date workers blockading the **CADIZ - MADRID** road were attacked barbarically by the police, leaving 50 wounded. The city was cut off by road, rail and telephone.

The workers mobilisations continued into June. On the 1st, a mass assembly decided to organise activity together with the workers in the largest firms in the region.

And things are still happening in the docks too. During the election campaign the dockers took strike action against the government's decision to privatise the docks.

contact: Etcetera, Apartado Correos 1363, Barcelona.

MINERS STRIKE BACK

British Coal management are still on the offensive, with the plans to introduce 6 day working and for more closures and redundancies. But sparks of resistance flared in Yorkshire on 1st May when 6,000 miners struck in support of the sacked miners. Unofficial pickets of sacked miners from Kent, Notts., and elsewhere stopped every pit in the Doncaster area.

CONFERENCE

Workers involved in recent struggles have called a conference to be held in Manchester Town Hall on July 25th at 12 noon. Groups involved include: Ancoats Casualty Sit-In, Ardbride Sacked Workers, Senior Colman Strike Committee, Trader Sacked Workers and their network of support groups. More details: c/o Gateshead Workers Support Group, 180 Two Ball Lonnen, Newcastle-upon-Tyne, NE4 9SB.

OCCUPIED!

On 4th March **Leicester** City Council decided to cut previous resources to the unemployed in their centre.

This was opposed by the unemployed and an occupation of the centre was set up with a free food kitchen and workshops, with the result of more people than ever using the centre.

Trade Union bureaucrats and Labour Party hacks encouraged employed people not to give help to the autonomously organised dolers.

Due to this, on April 7th after intimidation and threats of violence, the occupation stopped.

The campaign still continues for the fight for full facilities for the unemployed.

SNOOPERS

On 26th May members of Tottenham and Bethnal Green Claimants Unions and other claimants picketed snoopers squads at Hackney dole office in London. Claimants barged into the staff entrance, confronted the snoopers and warned them that they had better not be seen on the streets of Hackney. Photos of the snoopers were made into posters and also published in *Black Voice* and the local press.

STRIP SEARCHING

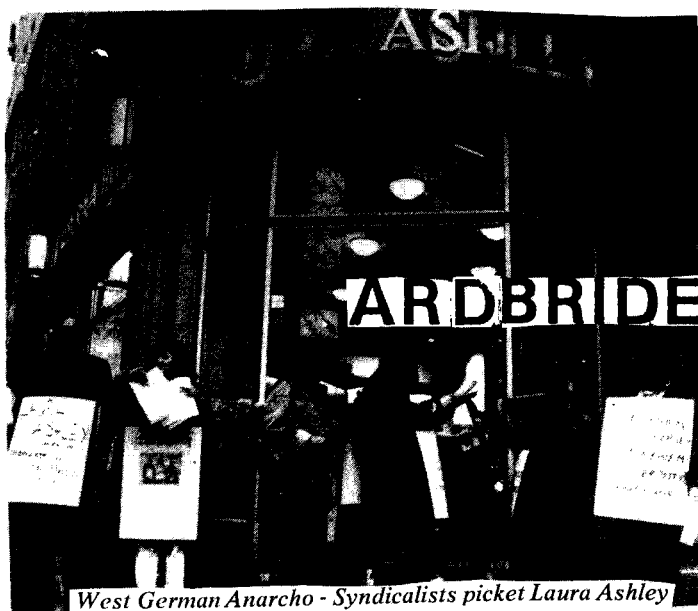
400 people picketed **Magherry**, (Europe's newest highest security prison, near Belfast) on **International Women's Day**, where Irish Republican women prisoners are subjected to strip searching. In a statement to the picket the 15 women prisoners condemned the practice as "legalised rape of mind and body." All women are forced to strip on entering and leaving the prison and are forcibly stripped if they refuse. In a prison covered with barbed wire, watchtowers, steel fencing and surveillance cameras, where visitors go through cages, tunnels, searches and 13 locked gates to reach the prisoners, strip searching is used by the state to demoralise the women and break their spirit.

Info: WARZINE

BLOWPIPES AGAINST BULLDOZERS

In North Borneo timber companies, owned by government officials, are cutting down the rainforest, leaving 5m acres of "moonscape". Now over 10 tribes have united to fight for their homes. Roads have been blocked, company bridges and machinery sabotaged and blowpipe attacks launched against logging camps.

Outwrite/Gabriela



West German Anarcho - Syndicalists picket Laura Ashley

The brave fight by the Ardbride strikers to win reinstatement and safe working conditions has ended in defeat. The Ardrossan factory workers reluctantly called off their 9 month strike in mid June - the number of active strikers had dwindled as sweatshop owner Ross continued to produce and sell his lampshades to Laura Ashley.

These luxury products were produced amongst toxic fumes and illegally high dust levels. From the west of Scotland factories the struggle against this exploitation spread worldwide. Pickets converged on Laura Ashley shops in the U.S.A., West Germany, France, Denmark, Ireland and in at least 19 towns in Britain. These solidarity pickets were organised by grass-roots activists including claimants groups, workplace activists, anarchists and the International Workers Association.

In April these actions and the strikers determination led to Ross offering the strikers £1,800 each to end the strike. The strikers would not be bought off. In late April came an offer of "re-engagement." The strikers could return to work - but as "new starts". This would have allowed Ross

to make them redundant anytime on the "last in, first out" principle. Ross offered nothing on health and safety.

The strikers were determined to stick out for their full demands. But then the TGWU - who had always done more to hinder than help the strikers - stepped in to aid the bosses. Local Union officials ordered the strikers to accept the offer. The women voted to continue the strike.

The union bosses then withdrew TGWU backing completely, even writing to Ross and Laura Ashley to apologise! The struggle continued for another 6 weeks, with the pickets of Laura Ashley spreading. But Laura Ashley maintained their commitment to goods produced at the expense of workers health. Laura Ashley drivers started to cross the Ardbride picket lines, and the strikers' hopes of victory faded.

The Ardbride strike shows yet again that workers can place no reliance whatsoever on the trade union bureaucrats, and ever more clear is the need for working class struggle to develop a solidarity and self-organisation that can carry forward and spread struggles independently.

the festival and drive them off the streets.

Fighting started up - burning barricades and cars were everywhere. The cops used sticks and tried to clear the place with tear gas. Loads of people joined the riot and kept the festival going!

Dozens of shops were looted or burned - people celebrated and had a big party with stuff from the supermarkets 'mysteriously' opened for free shopping!

For hours a large area of Kreuzberg was cop free.

ANTI-CENSUS CONT.

policies. They had at their disposal the most modern technologies. Since 1942 IBM was deeply involved in the development of nazi personal data systems.

On the same day as the police raid on the anti-census bureau 2,000 people held a street festival in the Berlin district Kreuzberg.

As a demonstration against the raid was forming, the cops tried brutally but unsuccessfully to disperse the people at

DEJA VU

The H.F.W. Plastics dispute in Gateshead has become a daily battle between police and pickets.

The strike began in March when 47 workers were sacked for refusing to sign a "loyalty oath". This followed an overtime ban over wages.

Scabs have been hired on 3 month contracts. Wages are £58 for women and £67 for men, over £30 less than the workers were receiving.

THE STRUGGLE CONTINUES AT TRADER

29 weeks of picketing the Heanor gate plant in Derbyshire, and picketing and 'actions' against major Trader advertisers is giving results. The sole source of income for the papers is advertising. Rates have been cut by 45% just to fill space. Like the bosses, the unions are also on the run.

SOGAT stopped strike pay after 20 weeks. The NGA almost withdrew until rank and file anger forced them to reconsider. However, they are still 'reviewing' this decision weekly. An NGA rep. on Notts. Trades Council blocked a £100 donation to a support group.

Co-operation and solidarity will win or lose this struggle, and thousands like it.

Donations and support to: Traders Sacked Workers Dispute, c/o 114 Stonehill Rd., Derby. Support group newsletter - S.A.E. and donation to Box 5, 115 Mansfield Rd., Nottingham.

Hundreds of people were injured, about 50 were arrested. The damage came to between 15 and 20 million DM.

In revenge for the riots, those arrested were treated very roughly in detention.

On 26 May, Norbert Kubat, 29, was apparently found hanged in his cell. A demonstration against his death of more than

Initially pickets were successful. Now police cordons, up to 100 strong, protect scabs and company lorries. (Non H.F.W. drivers are still respecting the picket line). Several pickets have been injured and dozens arrested. Solidarity demonstrations at Gateshead nick have become regular events. On May 1st scaffolding work on the police station halted when two workers walked off in support of arrested pickets.

Full time S.O.G.A.T. officials are trying to divide strikers from the growing local support with warnings against "Anarchists and Trotskyists". Remember Wapping!

Letters of support and donations to: H.F.W. Sacked Workers, c/o 119 Jesmond Road, Newcastle-upon-Tyne, NE2 1NL.

Info: "The Syndicalist".

BLAKES

Until recently, workers at Blakes' Engineering Co., Leith, have accepted low wages in return for management promises to improve poor working conditions. This resulted in wages £23/week below the national rate and no improvement in conditions.

At the end of April the workforce struck for a £10 wage rise. 27 were sacked and their jobs advertised in the "Evening News" at the rate the strikers had been demanding.

The sacked workers are picketing everyday. They have produced leaflets and made street collections supported by individual trade unionists and claimants. A womens support group has been formed.

CONTACT: R. Stevenson, 210 Bonnington Road, Edinburgh.

DISCLAIMER - Front Line Info, Combative group in Netherlands report that Info on Solidarity actions against Apartheid in CI No. 14 was incorrect.

1,500 people was attacked by police.

Info: Echomedia Berlin

The Counter Information collective invites people to - send us articles and information - take bundles of the news-sheet to distribute - make a much needed donation towards our printing and postage costs - write for info on our Readers Meetings and the CI "Supplement" - contact us if they'd like to join the CI collective. We wish to co-operate with all who share our aims.

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NOTE: The views expressed in reports from outside the collective are not necessarily totally shared by Counter Information.